The Personal Budget Spreadsheet — Quick-Start Guide

How to Use Your New Budget Planner (In Under 30 Minutes)

Empire Rewards — Free Edition

INTRODUCTION

You now have the spreadsheet. This guide shows you exactly how to use it — step by step, in under 30 minutes.

There are three things most people get wrong when they start budgeting:

1. **They try to track everything perfectly from day one.**
   Reality: estimates work fine for the first month. You'll refine as you go.
2. **They don't check the summary dashboard.**
   Reality: the dashboard is where the real insight lives. Total income, total expenses, remaining balance, savings rate.
3. **They forget to revisit it monthly.**
   Reality: a budget isn't a one-time exercise. It's a tool you update every 30 days.

This guide walks you through each step — from opening the file to reading your first real budget report.

Let's begin.

PART 1: BEFORE YOU OPEN THE FILE

What You Need

- **The spreadsheet file** (`personal-budget-spreadsheet.xlsx`)
- **A spreadsheet application** — Excel, Google Sheets (free), or Apple Numbers
- **Your last 30 days of bank and credit card statements** — for reference
- **About 30 minutes** — that's all it takes for the first setup

Which Version Should You Open?

The file works in **all three applications** without any changes:

If you use...	Open the file by...
Microsoft Excel	Double-click the `.xlsx` file
Google Sheets	Upload to Google Drive, then open with Sheets
Apple Numbers	Double-click the `.xlsx` file

Recommendation: If you don't already use Excel, open it in **Google Sheets**. It's free, syncs across devices, and lets you share the budget with a partner or spouse.

PART 2: THE SPREADSHEET TABS

When you open the file, you'll see 5 tabs at the bottom (or top) of the screen:

Tab 1: Dashboard

The summary view. Shows your total income, total expenses, remaining balance, and savings rate at a glance. This is what you check first every month.

Tab 2: Monthly Budget

The main working tab. Enter your income and expenses here, organized by category. This is where you'll do most of your data entry.

Tab 3: Savings Goals

Set target amounts and deadlines for each savings goal. Progress bars update automatically as you log deposits.

Tab 4: Debt Payoff

Track balances, interest rates, and minimum payments for each debt. See your projected payoff date with minimum payments and with extra payments.

Tab 5: Annual Overview

All 12 months side by side. Spot seasonal spending trends, compare months, and see your year at a glance.

PART 3: STEP-BY-STEP SETUP

Step 1: Enter Your Income (3 minutes)

Open the **Monthly Budget** tab.

At the top, you'll see a section for income. There are 4 pre-built rows:

- Primary salary
- Secondary income (side hustle, freelance)
- Investment income
- Other

What to do:

- Enter your **take-home** pay (not gross) for each source
- If you get paid bi-weekly, add both paychecks for the month
- The total calculates automatically

Example:

Income Source	Amount
Primary salary	$3,800
Side hustle	$400
Total	**$4,200**

Step 2: Fill In Fixed Expenses (5 minutes)

Scroll down to the **Housing** and **Transportation** sections. These are usually your largest fixed costs.

Housing (8 categories):

- Rent/mortgage
- Utilities (electric, gas, water)
- Internet
- Home insurance
- Property tax
- HOA fees
- Repairs/maintenance
- Lawn care

Transportation (7 categories):

- Car payment
- Gas
- Car insurance
- Maintenance
- Registration
- Parking
- Public transit

What to do: Enter the amount you pay monthly for each. Leave blank if you don't have that expense. The spreadsheet will total each section.

Step 3: Fill In Variable Expenses (10 minutes)

Next, fill in the sections for **Food**, **Health**, and **Personal**.

Food (5 categories):

- Groceries
- Dining out
- Coffee shops
- Meal delivery
- Work lunches

Health (6 categories):

- Health insurance
- Medications
- Doctor visits
- Dental
- Vision
- Gym membership

Personal (9 categories):

- Clothing
- Entertainment
- Subscriptions
- Hobbies
- Gifts
- Personal care
- Pets
- Education
- Miscellaneous

What to do: For the first month, estimates work fine. Use your bank statements to get realistic numbers. It doesn't need to be perfect — you'll refine next month.

Step 4: Set Your Savings & Debt (5 minutes)

Finally, fill in the **Savings & Debt** section (8 categories):

- Emergency fund
- Retirement contribution
- Investments
- Credit card payments
- Student loan payments
- Medical debt payments
- Car loan payments
- Personal loan payments

What to do: Enter the amount you're currently putting toward each.

Step 5: Review The Dashboard (2 minutes)

Now open the **Dashboard** tab.

You'll see:

- **Total income** — what you have coming in
- **Total expenses** — what you have going out
- **Remaining balance** — income minus expenses
- **Savings rate** — your savings + debt payments as a % of income
- **Category breakdown** — where your money is going

What to look for:

- **Positive remaining balance** → You're spending less than you earn. Good.
- **Negative remaining balance** → You're overspending. Time to adjust.
- **Savings rate below 20%** → Try to increase this gradually.

PART 4: HOW TO READ THE DASHBOARD

The dashboard is the most important tab. Here's how to interpret each number.

Total Income

Everything you have coming in this month. Should match the income section of the Monthly Budget tab.

Total Expenses

Everything you have going out this month. If this exceeds income, you're spending more than you earn.

Remaining Balance

Income minus expenses. This is what's left after all planned spending.

- **Positive number:** You have room. Redirect extra to savings.
- **Zero:** You're breaking even. Consider trimming a "want" category.
- **Negative number:** You're overspending. Time to adjust.

Savings Rate

The percentage of your income going toward savings and extra debt payments.

- **Under 10%:** Minimal. Try to increase gradually.
- **10–19%:** Reasonable, but not ideal.
- **20%+:** On track for long-term financial health.
- **30%+:** Excellent — you're building wealth quickly.

Category Breakdown

This shows where your money is actually going vs. what you planned. Common surprises:

- **Food** — usually the biggest overspending category
- **Personal** — subscriptions and dining out creep up
- **Housing** — often higher than you think (utilities, repairs, insurance)

PART 5: USING THE SAVINGS GOALS TAB

This tab lets you track specific goals — emergency fund, vacation, down payment, new car, etc.

How to Set Up a Goal

1. Open the **Savings Goals** tab
2. Enter the goal name (e.g., "Emergency Fund")
3. Enter the target amount (e.g., $5,000)
4. Enter the target date (e.g., Dec 31, 2026)
5. The spreadsheet calculates how much you need to save each month

How to Track Progress

Each month, enter the amount you've deposited into the goal. The progress bar updates automatically.

Example:

Goal	Target	Monthly Needed	Saved So Far	Progress
Emergency Fund	$5,000	$417	$1,250	 25%
Vacation	$2,000	$167	$500	 25%

PART 6: USING THE DEBT PAYOFF TAB

This is where the spreadsheet gets powerful. It shows you exactly how long until you're debt-free.

How to Set Up Each Debt

1. Open the **Debt Payoff** tab
2. Enter for each debt:

- Debt name
- Current balance
- Interest rate (APR)
- Minimum monthly payment

3. The spreadsheet calculates:

- Payoff date with minimum payments only
- Payoff date with extra payments applied
- Total interest paid in each scenario
- Interest saved by paying extra

The Snowball vs. Avalanche Decision

The tab lets you choose your strategy:

Snowball:

- Pay minimums on everything
- Throw extra money at the smallest balance first
- Once paid off, roll that payment into the next smallest
- **Best for:** Motivation and momentum

Avalanche:

- Pay minimums on everything
- Throw extra money at the highest interest rate first
- Once paid off, roll that payment into the next highest rate
- **Best for:** Saving the most money on interest

Real Example

Setup:

- Credit card: $3,000 balance, 22% APR, $90 minimum
- Car loan: $8,000 balance, 6% APR, $250 minimum
- Student loan: $15,000 balance, 5% APR, $200 minimum
- Extra payment available: $500/month

Result:

Strategy	Payoff Time	Total Interest
Minimum payments only	8 years 2 months	$6,840
Snowball (smallest first)	4 years 9 months	$2,940
Avalanche (highest rate first)	4 years 9 months	$2,900

Either strategy saves over **$3,900** in interest — just by adding $500/month.

PART 7: MONTHLY MAINTENANCE

Once your budget is set up, this is what you do every month.

The Monthly Review (30 minutes)

Do this on the first of every month, or on payday.

1. **Open the Monthly Budget tab**
2. **Update actual expenses** from the previous month
3. **Check the Dashboard** for your income, expenses, and savings rate
4. **Adjust any categories** that came in over or under
5. **Update savings goals** with what you actually saved
6. **Update debt balances** as you pay them down

The Annual Deep Dive (1–2 hours)

Once a year, do a more thorough review:

1. **Open the Annual Overview tab**
2. **Compare all 12 months** side by side
3. **Identify patterns** — which months have higher spending?

4. **Set next year's goals** based on what you learned
5. **Adjust category targets** for the year ahead

PART 8: FIVE HABITS THAT MAKE BUDGETS WORK

The spreadsheet is a tool. These habits make it stick.

1. Check the Dashboard Weekly

Every Sunday, open the Dashboard. It takes 2 minutes. It keeps you aware of where you stand.

2. Enter Purchases the Same Day

Keep receipts or use your bank app. Enter expenses as they happen. When you batch at the end of the month, you miss details.

3. Give Every Dollar a Job

Every dollar of income should be assigned to a category — spending, saving, or debt. If money is "unassigned," it disappears.

4. Review One Category Per Week

Deep-dive one category each week. Look at every transaction. This is where most people find waste.

5. Adjust Every Month

Your first month's budget will be wrong. Your second will be closer. Your third will be accurate. Don't expect perfection on day one.

PART 9: COMMON QUESTIONS

What if I have irregular income?

Use the **average of the last 3 months** as your starting estimate. Update as you go. The spreadsheet handles any amount you enter.

What if I don't know my exact expenses?

Estimates work fine for the first month. Use your bank statement as a guide. You'll refine in month two.

Can I share this with my partner?

Yes. If you're using Google Sheets, you can share the file with your partner's email so you both see the same budget in real-time. In Excel, use the sharing feature or save it to a shared drive.

How often should I update it?

- **Weekly:** Check the dashboard
- **Monthly:** Full review and category update
- **Yearly:** Deep dive on the Annual Overview tab

What if my expenses exceed my income?

Two options:

1. **Reduce expenses** — start with "want" categories (dining out, subscriptions, entertainment)
2. **Increase income** — see our free Side Hustle Starter Kit for 50 income ideas

Usually, it's a combination of both.

CONCLUSION

You now have:

- A complete budget spreadsheet with 50+ categories
- A dashboard that shows your full financial picture
- A savings goal tracker
- A debt payoff calculator with snowball vs. avalanche comparison
- A 12-month annual overview
- A monthly maintenance system

The only thing left is to start. Open the file. Enter your income. Enter your first three expenses. That's enough for day one.

By month three, you'll have a budget that actually reflects your life — and money that actually goes where you want it to.

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